



VIA NOVA

SPRING NEWSLETTER

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VIA THIS SPRING

Via is a program designed for young people that integrates study, work, and prayer into a year-long experience. It offers a *via nova* or "new way" to cultivate life-changing habits, gain practical knowledge, and live a life seeking freedom and mission. The activities we engage in at Via strengthen both community life and personal growth within a structured environment. It equips young people with the tools and mindset needed to navigate the complexities of the modern world.

At the heart of Via lies a community where hungry young people are nourished with the means to achieve their goals. This is accomplished through a combination of seminars, apprenticeships, structured prayer, and an active community life. By welcoming friends and family into our house, we invite them to join us in our mission of cultivating a rich and fulfilling life.

Over the past spring, we have hosted a variety of events aimed at intellectual and spiritual growth, including discussions on hypocrisy and sacred art, lectures on Platonic philosophy and on the distinction between the sacred and the holy, a few poetry nights, praise on the porch, jam sessions, movie nights, and presentations on Greek philosophy, ancient Roman literature and ancient Christianity. The fellows conclude the year with a silent retreat in Grand Coteau.



Over the past year, my passion for creating music has deepened. I've found it to be an incredibly fulfilling hobby that not only allows me to express emotions but also helps build community.



Via went on a pilgrimage to Mexico, where we visited many sacred and beautiful churches. Here is part of our group in front of a stunningly ornate church located in a poor area of Cholula. The locals were only able to afford this Church by each family pitching in for the building process. It was inspiring to see how they prioritized the beauty of their Church even over modern comforts.



We host a "Poetry Night" about once a month. These evenings create a space that fosters deep conversations and strengthens our community. These evenings offer us a chance to learn from great authors and gradually uncover truths about humanity and the world around us. Each of these evenings has impacted me, particularly by hearing my friends' different interpretations of poetry.



Together, we celebrate and connect with our local community through songs of praise to God during "Praise on the Porch."



Dr. Michael Foley discussed the difference between the sacred and the holy at the Via House. Dr. Foley explained that sacredness refers to things set apart for divine use, while holiness pertains to beings, divine or human, filled with the Holy Spirit and sanctifying grace.

Hosting gatherings focused on meaningful discussion has created healthy relationships and strengthened the local community of Lafayette. Attending these events has planted a seed of curiosity and a desire to learn for its own sake within me. I've also noticed an eagerness among my friends for deeper knowledge and more meaningful conversations. The events we host seem to feed the intellect in a way young people need. The Fellows and I have witnessed the importance of the intellectual life through our events, and will continue attending even after this year.

LIVING INTENTIONALLY

This spring, I've seen significant growth by practicing intentionality and self-reflection. Living in the present moment has always been challenging for me, especially when my schedule lacks order. However, when I have a structured day, it's much easier to be present with others. Life becomes more enjoyable when you can fully be there for the experiences and people around you every day. I've come to find that Intentionality and self-reflection are the tools that allow me to appreciate the small, ordinary things in life.

Earlier this year, we studied Aristotle. In his *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle suggests that happiness is our ultimate goal, driving all our actions. He views happiness as a gift, which has shifted my perspective on life. Through seeing happiness as a gift, I have come to see more broadly all of life also being a gift. In general we value gifts. We should take care of everything that is gifted to us. Likewise, if we see life as a gift, we'll naturally value it more. There's a lot more intentionality in how we treat life when we recognize it as a gift given from God. Every night for the last few months, I've reflected on my day. In doing this, I have realized that self-reflection naturally builds intentionality. I get more out of my day when I take time to reflect. It helps me see where I can improve and adds more value to my life. But I've found that happiness comes from living intentionally in pursuit of not mere earthly happiness as a good in itself, but relationship with God.

NEXT STEPS

As the year draws to a close, I've been contemplating my future plans, and have been wrestling with the question "What ought I do with my life?" This question often gets pushed aside especially by young people. I find the longer it remains unaddressed, the more stress accumulates. I have been fortunate enough to have been surrounded with good people actively searching for the answer. I realized I was asking the wrong question, one that was self-centered. I shifted my perspective and came to realize the questions I should be asking myself are: "What is God calling me to do in life," "How can I love God and my neighbor through my life," and "How can I serve in my vocation?" By reframing this question, things slowly started to become clearer. I had to think about who I am, the gifts I have been given, and how can I use them wisely to serve others.

I've discovered that I have a passion for creating beautiful things. I would love to channel this passion to help others through some good or service. I don't know practically what this will look like, but that is okay. This is a continuous question I will wrestle with throughout life, and I've come to learn it takes small steps to move closer to the answer. In the meantime, I plan to dedicate time to learning and working in various fields, aiming to further develop my personal creative talents.

Via has broadened my professional network, connecting me with various experts across multiple fields including architecture, civil engineering, business, real estate, contracting, accounting, and project management. These conversations have provided me with a real-world perspective on various career paths. I highly recommend that every young person engage in these types of conversations before making any commitments, as they can prevent potential regrets about career choices. Personally, these discussions have solidified my decision to pursue either architecture or general contracting this fall. Without this year of discernment and character-building, I wouldn't be able to say with confidence that I am on the right path for my future.



Father Francisco led our seminars on spiritual exegesis in Mexico City. We learned how to read scripture with the lens of the ancient tradition.



"Lundi Gras" was an opportunity for the wider community to embrace the tradition of our Cajun culture.



Throughout the spring, we've participated in "sequences" of seminars, beginning with Greek philosophy, followed by Ancient Rome, and concluding with Ancient Christianity led by Dr. Cory Hayes (pictured above). Our final sequence focused on Matthew's gospel, as well as works by Athenagoras, Mathetes, Origen, Tertullian, and Augustine. In these readings we reflected on how the Christian should live their life even within a corrupt society.

Below are various photos from our year. On the far right is a picture of Juan Diego's tilma, which is located in Mexico City. Approximately 500 years ago, Our Lady appeared to Juan Diego and left an imprint of herself on this tilma. We were fortunate enough to be able to visit the image that Our Lady imposed herself on. Seeing Our Lady was a profoundly moving experience for me. I was struck by the beauty of the image and its remarkable preservation, which made me reflect on the transcendent beauty of God. This experience was truly impactful, and I am forever grateful for it.



THANK YOU

Thank you for all of the prayers and support. I am so grateful for the opportunity to have done Via this past year. This has truly been the most impactful experience of my life so far. It couldn't have been created without the support from the broader community and my personal support team, so thank you. I am grateful for all of the wonderful people I have met, all of the invaluable lessons I have learned, all of the unforgettable memories, and finally for the clarity it has provided in my life. Please keep Via, the other Fellows, and myself in your prayers as we move forward.

Please feel free to reach out to me with any prayer requests or simply to check in at anthony@studyworkpray.org. It would be a privilege to pray for you and for your intentions.

God bless you,
Anthony Salvatierra